

Moonsea Backgrounds

These backgrounds are meant to replace the Backgrounds covered in the Player's Handbook. These backgrounds are just that - backgrounds. They do not have to dictate where your character goes from here, but they should be a big part of the story of how your character came to be in the capital city of the Moonsea Empire and interested or involved in playing the game of intrigue.

Athletic Champion

Your physique and skill brought you into the public eye, and a winning smile helps you stay there. Moonsea honors its extraordinary athletes, celebrating them as cultural heroes. Whether you were a gladiator, a runner, a wrestler, or any other competitor, your most recent victory caused someone important to sit up and take notice. You may or may not have a political career in front of you, but for now your name is helping to bring a little extra money in, and maybe that's good enough.

Skill Proficiencies: Athletics, Acrobatics

Tool Proficiencies: you are proficient in an inexpensive but unusual weapon of your choice (subject to DM approval) - e.g., trident+net, whip, double psi, etc.

Equipment: A masterwork version of the weapon you chose for your proficiency, the favor of an admirer (love letter, lock of hair, or trinket), a recognizable costume/outfit/armor used when you perform, a belt pouch containing 100 gp

Advantages

You gain advantage on either Athletics or Acrobatics (you choose at character creation) checks that relate to your chosen athletic prowess (e.g., running for a runner, holding your breath for a swimmer, grappling for a wrestler, etc.).

You can take 10 on any constitution check that relates to your chosen athletic prowess (e.g., running for a runner, holding your breath for a swimmer, grappling for a wrestler, etc.).

Feature: Immovable Object

You go where you want to go and are difficult to move; you gain a +2 bonus on checks to navigate through a crowd or resist being moved against your will, including spells, bull rush, drag, and being pushed/shoved/moved in combat.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Entertainer background, or come up with your own.

Minor Noble

You belong to a minor noble family (you can choose to be a member of a major noble family, but that requires you to take the Noble Scion feat at 1st level, which you may do only if you are Variant Human). Your family is known in Melvaunt and they have connections. As the story begins you may or may not be on good terms with your relatives. Your upbringing among the city's well-to-do gives you an upper hand when it comes to knowledge of high society, and you start the game with a modest inheritance or income. With the winds of change blowing in the capital, new lines are being quietly drawn in the sand, and you have found yourself embroiled in these intrigues whether you intended to be or not.

Skill Proficiencies: History, Persuasion

Tool Proficiencies: One type of gaming set

Languages: one of your choice among those spoken among noble families of Melvaunt

Equipment: A set of fine clothes, a signet ring, a scroll of pedigree, and a purse containing 400 gp

Advantages

You gain advantage on any Persuasion check where your character reasonably uses some version of the rhetorical question, "Do you have any idea who I am?"

You gain advantage on all History checks to recall some aspect a Melvaunt noble family's history.

The Noble Scion feat does not have a Charisma prerequisite for you.

Feature: There's No Place Like Home

With this archetype, the assumption is that you belong to a minor noble family (and can make up your family name). In this case, your family keeps a small manor somewhere in the city, perhaps in the Scribes District, Satin District, or Petal District, where you and your party can rest, acquire healing, minor supplies and have access to a staff of servants to run errands for you.

If you want to be a member of one of Melvaunt's major noble families, you must take the Noble Scion feat at 1st level, which you may do only if you are Variant Human.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Noble background, or come up with your own.

Disgraced Noble

Your noble family used to matter, until someone in your family (your father, mother, sibling, etc.) took a stand against a VIP (possibly, High Stormreaver Maxillar Bruel, the commander of Moonsea's military, or Terrian El Gata, also known as the King of Trade, or perhaps a powerful Senator like Benvolio Baregon or Lawrence Marsk). Unfortunately, your family member's virtuous stand had disastrous social consequences, leading to a powerful and effective set of illicit accusations or disgraceful rumors. True or not, the accusations leveled against your family in return destroyed your reputation and isolated you from the society you grew up in. Now, the only thing that matters to you is clawing your way back up the social ladder, either for your own quality of life or to clear your family's name or perhaps to take your revenge.

Skill Proficiencies: Deception, Persuasion

Tool Proficiencies: One type of gaming set, thieves tools

Languages: one of your choice

Equipment: A set of fine clothes, a signet ring, and a purse containing 100 gp

Advantages

You gain advantage on Deception checks to conceal your identity.

You gain advantage on Investigation checks to spot or produce forgeries.

Feature: Hello, My Name is Inigo Montoya

You are relentlessly focused on righting the wrong done to your family. Once each day, you can choose a single humanoid you believe to have been involved in the conspiracy to destroy your family; you gain advantage on attacks against that NPC for a number of rounds equal to your character level.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Noble background, or come up with your own.

Rising Star

All too often, great minds must suffer for their art, but you're one of the lucky ones. You are an artist, performer, inventor, or a genius at some other celebrated craft or art. Your skills attracted the attention of a noble patron who pays for your food, housing, and tools. As your patron introduces you to other cultural elites, the demands of fame and always being "on" weigh heavily on you. You're slowly learning to navigate the treacherous waters of high society, but you still remember the lean times when each meal was a hard-won treasure.

Skill Proficiencies: Performance/Insight (choose one), Persuasion

Tool Proficiencies: One type of artisan tools or musical instrument

Languages: one of your choice

Equipment: A set of artisan tools or musical instrument of your choice (a gift from your patron), a small token of your patron's support (e.g., a letter, signet ring, etc.), a set of fine clothes, and a belt pouch containing 50 gp.

Advantages

You gain advantage on any Performance check to engage in your chosen art.

You gain advantage on Persuasion checks when dealing with someone who is familiar with (and does not have a negative view of) your work, regardless of whether they know your patron.

Feature: Perhaps You've Heard of My Patron?

Once each day, you can invoke your patron's reputation or name one of your own prominent works to add twice your proficiency bonus to a single Deception, Intimidation, or Persuasion check. If the check is one that already gets a proficiency bonus, you may still only double the bonus once.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Entertainer background, or the Guild Artisan background, or come up with your own.

Senatorial Hopeful

While you belong to a noble family, hailing from the outlying provinces means you lack the pull and wealth needed to rub shoulders with the stars of Melvaunt's social scene. Your life has been quiet, isolated from the thrum of fashion and pop culture, but you see this as a source of insight and that can help you someday gain a seat in the senate. It'll be a long journey, but

you've already begun learning which hands to shake and how to listen carefully when others tell you what they want. You claim to speak for the constituents of your home province or city and, whether genuine or not, you know the ability to achieve gains for your people will be vital to your success.

Skill Proficiencies: History, Persuasion

Tool Proficiencies: One type of gaming set

Languages: one of your choice spoken in your home province

Equipment: A set of fine clothes, a signet ring, a scroll of pedigree, and a purse containing 100 gp

Advantages

You gain advantage on Persuasion checks when speaking to a noble from outside of Melvaunt.

You gain advantage on History checks about past events in your home province.

Feature: I know a Guy

Once each week you can call on family connections to obtain a single piece of equipment or consumable magic item (such as a potion or scroll) worth up to your character level x 25 gp. Delivery of the goods you request takes 1-4 days. At 10th level the potential value of a magical item increases to your character level x 50 gp, and your requests can also include spellcasting services and wands.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Noble background, or come up with your own.

Moonsea Patriot

You love your country, its history, and its people... even though they may not love you back. Whether you're a bureaucrat, a minor noble, a sailor, or a soldier, you are a loyal servant of the people of Moonsea.

(Soldier Variant)

Skill Proficiencies: Athletics, Intimidation

Tool Proficiencies: Navigator's tools, vehicles (water)

Equipment: An insignia of rank, trophy taken from a fallen enemy (dagger, broken blade, or a piece of banner, etc.), a set of bone dice or deck of cards, a set of common clothes, and a belt pouch containing 25 gp.

(Sailor Variant)

Skill Proficiencies: Acrobatics, Perception

Tool Proficiencies: One type of gaming set, vehicles (land)

Equipment: A belaying pin (club), 50 ft of silk rope, a lucky charm, a set of common clothes, and a belt pouch containing 25 gp.

(Bureaucrat Variant)

Skill Proficiencies: History, Investigation

Tool Proficiencies: Calligrapher's Supplies, Cartographer's Tools, or Forgery Kit (choose one)

Languages: two of your choice

Equipment: A set of the kind of tools chosen above, a letter of access giving you access to the building where your office is located, an impressive hat, robes of office, an ink pen, a bottle of ink, and a purse containing 50 gp.

Advantages

You gain advantage on Investigation checks to gather information from a member of your segment of Moonsea society: soldier, sailor, bureaucrat (you must choose at character creation).

You gain advantage on Persuasion checks against any current or former colleague, including people who may not have known you personally, but served in the same department, regiment, etc.

Feature: My Best Friend's Sister's Boyfriend's Brother's Girlfriend Heard from This Guy

Once per day you can recall a specific fact about a member of your segment of Moonsea society: soldier, sailor, bureaucrat (you must choose at character creation). The kinds of facts you can recall must be the kind that might be the subject of office scuttlebut, such as personality quirks, hobbies, pet peeves, past well-known indiscretions, and other kinds of information you would normally learn via an Investigation check.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Knight, Soldier, Sailor, background, or for the bureaucrat variant, you might try those listed here: <https://richardgreengames.com/2021/04/07/bureaucrat-5e-background/> , or come up with your own.

Young Reformer

Perhaps you were born at the bottom of Moonsea society and you're tired of seeing your friends and family toil endlessly with no hope of a better life, or maybe your privileged outlook was shattered by empathy or tragedy. Either way, you know the system is broken, and you've dedicated your life to fixing it. But tradition rules Moonsea as much as any Stormlord, and change requires more influence than you have ... so far. You've got friends and allies, and plenty of determination, but while you work toward the power you need to change the nation, you'll have to resort to more discrete ways of righting wrongs and curbing the abuses you perceive.

(Noble Variant)

Skill Proficiencies: History, Persuasion

Tool Proficiencies: One type of gaming set

Languages: one of your choice among those spoken among noble families of Melvaunt

Equipment: A set of fine clothes, a signet ring, a scroll of pedigree, and a purse containing 100 gp

(Bureaucrat Variant)

Skill Proficiencies: Insight, Investigation

Tool Proficiencies: Calligrapher's Supplies, Cartographer's Tools, or Forgery Kit (choose one)

Languages: one of your choice

Equipment: A set of the kind of tools chosen above, a letter of access giving you access to the building where your office is located, a set of society clothes, and a belt pouch containing 50 gp.

Advantages

You gain advantage on Persuasion checks when promoting a change or reform to society.

You gain advantage on Insight checks to determine another person's disposition toward a given political faction.

Feature: Do You Hear the People Sing?

Once per day, you can call upon your co-conspirators to have "made arrangements" on your behalf, allowing you to attempt History check in place of a single Deception, Intimidate, Sleight of Hand, or Intelligence/Wisdom (disarm trap) check. You may add double your proficiency bonus to this check. The DC of this check is equal to the DC of the skill check it replaces.

Whatever arrangements you make — for doors left unlocked, guards strong-armed out of your way, stolen keys left for you to find — must be reasonable to have anticipated and achieved beforehand; you could arrange to have a noble convinced you're a very important diplomat traveling in disguise, for example, but if a fight breaks out you could not rely on your network of contacts to feint for you in combat. You don't have to use this ability in advance; you can announce its use as you encounter a challenge, implying you foresaw this challenge and made arrangements prior to your arrival.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Noble background or for the bureaucrat variant, you might try those listed here: <https://richardgreengames.com/2021/04/07/bureaucrat-5e-background/> or come up with your own.

Secret Agent

You are not really who you say you are. You might not even be from the Moonsea region, but almost no one in the Empire is aware of that fact. Indeed, you lead a double life - you have the identity everyone knows, plus the secret identity that is who you really are. You might come from another part of Faerun, perhaps a nation or organization that has good reasons to send spies to keep tabs on the Stormlord and the Moonsea Empire. You might represent a cautious Moonsea ally, or a sworn enemy of the state, but either way, you have developed the skills and abilities necessary to hide in plain sight.

Skill Proficiencies: Stealth, Deception

Tool Proficiencies: forgery kit, thieves tools

Languages: two of your choice

Equipment: a forgery kit, thieves tools, a secret token of your affiliation (something small you can show another agent to establish your bona fides), a set of fine clothes, and a belt pouch containing 50 gp

Advantages

You gain advantage on Deception checks to conceal your identity.

You gain advantage on Investigation checks to spot or produce forgeries.

Feature: When the Bullet Hits the Bone

Once per day, you can call upon a local asset to have "made arrangements" on your behalf, allowing you to attempt a Deception or Investigation check (you must choose at character creation) in place of a single Deception/Investigation (whichever you didn't choose), Perception, Sleight of Hand, or Intelligence/Wisdom (disarm trap) check. You may add double your proficiency bonus to this check. The DC of this check is equal to the DC of the skill check it replaces.

Whatever arrangements you make — for doors left unlocked, guards strong-armed out of your way, stolen keys left for you to find — must be reasonable to have anticipated and achieved beforehand; you could arrange to have a noble convinced you're a very important diplomat traveling in disguise, for example, but if a fight breaks out you could not rely on your network of contacts to feint for you in combat. You don't have to use this ability in advance; you can announce its use as you encounter a challenge, implying you foresaw this challenge and made arrangements prior to your arrival.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Charlatan, Criminal, or Noble background, or come up with your own.

Eschatologist

You have seen a glimpse of the future, and it consumes you. Whether you saw it in a vision, unearthed the truth while poring over ancient texts, read it in the stars, or simply woke one day with the knowledge fully formed in your head, you know the truth about ... **something** epic. It might be the identity of the next Stormlord, the fall of the Moonsea Empire, a major war between nations, or even the end of the world! You may be driven by a need to spread the truth to all who will listen, or you may be driven to prevent the end at all costs - or to ensure that it comes about as you saw it.

Skill Proficiencies: Arcana, Religion

Tool Proficiencies: two of your choice

Languages: two of your choice

Equipment: a bottle of black ink, a quill, a small knife, a letter from someone you told reacting to your claims, a set of common clothes, and a belt pouch containing 25 gp.

Advantages

You gain advantage on Persuasion or Intimidation checks in which you describe or explain your vision.

You gain advantage on Arcana or Religion checks (you must choose one at character creation) involving a single person, institution, or place that plays an important role in your vision.

Feature: All Of This Has Happened Before And Will Happen Again

You are relentlessly focused on either stopping or fulfilling your prophecy. Once per day you can “recall” a specific piece of information about someone or something you believe to have been involved in the subject of your vision/revelation. The contours of your powers are hazy, and these “flash forwards” are sometimes confusing or ambiguous. The more the information is the kind that could be gleaned from an Investigation check, the less ambiguous and hazy.

Personality Traits, Ideals, Bonds, and Flaws: Feel free to use the tables from the Acolyte, Noble, or Sage background, or come up with your own.